A Landslide in Alaska Made a Giant Tsunami

From: ScienceDaily Most Popular Mined: 2026-10-20 3 min read

In August 2025, part of a mountain in Alaska fell into the sea. The falling rock made the second-highest **tsunami** ever recorded.

It happened in Tracy Arm, a long, narrow inlet of the sea called a **fjord**. Water and rocks rushed 1,580 feet up the other side. That is taller than the top floor of Taipei 101, a very tall **skyscraper**. Luckily, it was early in the morning, and no ships were nearby.

Scientists at the Alaska Earthquake Center studied what happened. They found warning signs. The **glacier** below had shrunk a lot. Heavy rain had soaked into cracks in the mountain. Instruments also picked up thousands of tiny shakes, called **tremors**, in the days before.

The scientists think these clues could have warned people at least a day early. They want an alert system with yellow, orange and red levels. The U.S. does not have one like this yet.

Word Treasure

tsunami -- Very big waves caused when something suddenly pushes a lot of water.

fjord -- A long, narrow arm of the sea between steep cliffs.

glacier -- A giant, slow-moving river of ice.

tremors -- Tiny shakes of the ground, like very small earthquakes.

skyscraper -- A very tall building with many floors.

Background you need

A landslide happens when rocks and dirt suddenly slide down a steep slope.

When a lot of rock falls into water, it pushes the water up into huge waves.

Scientists use special instruments to feel tiny shakes in the ground.

Break it down

WHO: Scientists at the Alaska Earthquake Center
WHAT: A landslide made the second-highest tsunami ever recorded
WHERE: Tracy Arm, a fjord in Alaska
WHY: A shrinking glacier and heavy rain made the mountain unstable

Why it matters

Warning systems could help keep people on boats and near the coast safe, just like fire drills help keep you safe at school.

Test what you remember

1. What made the giant tsunami in Alaska?

- (A) A whale jumping
- (B) A thunderstorm
- (C) Part of a mountain falling into the sea
- (D) A big boat

2. How high did the water rush up the other side?

- (A) 15 feet
- (B) 15,800 feet
- (C) 158 feet
- (D) 1,580 feet

3. Why was no one hurt?

- (A) There was a big wall
- (B) The wave was tiny
- (C) Everyone was asleep on a ship
- (D) It was early morning and no ships were nearby

4. Which of these was a warning sign?

- (A) Birds sang loudly
- (B) Heavy rain soaked into cracks in the mountain
- (C) A rainbow appeared
- (D) The sea froze

5. What are tremors?

- (A) Kinds of fish
- (B) Tiny shakes in the ground
- (C) Big trucks
- (D) Snowflakes

6. What colors would the alert system use?

- (A) Blue and green
- (B) Black and white
- (C) Pink and purple
- (D) Yellow, orange and red

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: D 3: D 4: B 5: B 6: D

Questions to think about

1. Alaska Earthquake Center scientists: Think the warning signs could have alerted people at least a day early.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):